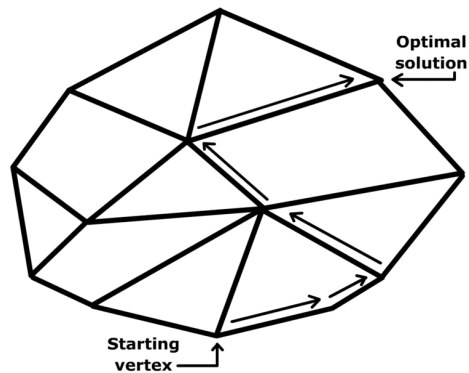


Lesson 28: Solving Linear Programs



linear programming, simplex methods, iterative search

Recap

- Linear programs are problems that can be formulated as follows

$$\min_x c \cdot x$$

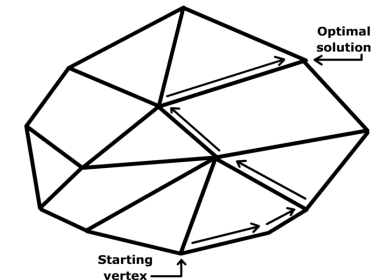
subject to

$$A^{\leq} x \leq b^{\leq}, \quad A^{\geq} x \geq b^{\geq}, \quad A^{\text{=}} x = b^{\text{=}}, \quad x \geq 0$$

- Where $x = (x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n)$
- A^* are matrices and we interpret the inequalities to mean

$$\forall k \quad \sum_{j=1}^n A_{kj}^{\leq} x_j \leq b_k^{\leq}$$

- Recap
- Basic Feasible Solutions
- Simplex Method
- Classic LP Problems



Optima and Vertices

- Because the objective function is linear ($c \cdot x$) there is a direction where the objective is always improving
- Thus, the optima cannot lie in the interior of the search space
- When we meet a constraint that limits the direction we can move, but we can still move along the constraint
- We then meet another constraint which restricts the direction we can move by two degrees of freedom
- Eventually, we will reach m constraints which defines a vertex of the feasible region and is optimal

Transforming Linear Programs

- We can always transform an inequality constraint into an equality constraint by adding slack variables

- E.g.

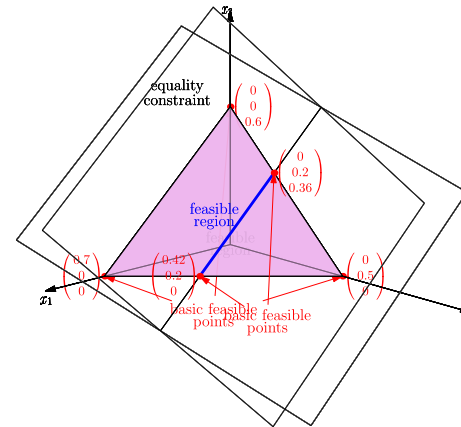
$$a_1 \cdot x \geq 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad a_1 \cdot x - z_1 = 0 \quad z_1 \geq 0$$

$$a_2 \cdot x \leq 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad a_2 \cdot x + z_2 = 0 \quad z_2 \geq 0$$

z_1 (the excess) and z_2 (the deficit) are known as slack variables

- A linear program with just equality constraints and non-negativity constraints is said to be in normal form

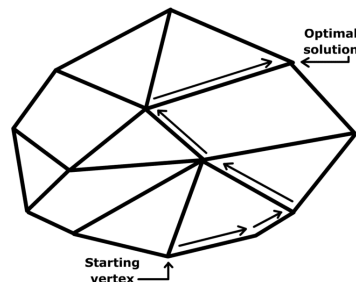
Solving Linear Programming



- The basic feasible points for LP problems with n variables and m constraints have at least $n - m$ zero variables
- Typical number of basic feasible solutions is $\binom{n}{m} \geq \left(\frac{n}{m}\right)^m$
- Simplex algorithm organises iterative search for global solutions

Outline

1. Recap
2. **Basic Feasible Solutions**
3. Simplex Method
4. Classic LP Problems



Basic Feasible Solution

- A *basic feasible solution* or *basic feasible point* is a solution that lies at a vertex of the feasible space
- To solve a linear program we will start at a basic feasible point and move to the neighbour which best improves the objective function
- When we cannot find a better solution we are at the optimal solution
- This is an example of an iterative improvement algorithm which gives an optimal solution

Constraints

- There are two types of constraints
 1. n non-negativity constraints $x_i \geq 0$
 2. m additional constraints, which we can take to be equalities
$$\mathbf{Ax} = \mathbf{b}$$
- Note that some of the variables might be slack variables
- We consider the case when there are more variables than additional constraints, i.e. $n > m$
- This is usually be the case, but. . .
- If this isn't true it turns out you can consider an equivalent problem (dual problem) where you have a variable for each constraint and a constraint for each variable

Basic Variable

- In total we have n equality and m non-negativity constraints
- m constraints must be satisfied to be at a vertex of feasible region
- So at least $n - m$ of the non-negativity constraints are satisfied (i.e. $x_i = 0$)
- The $n - m$ variables that are zero are said to be **non-basic variables**
- The other m variables are said to be **basic variables**

Initial Basic Feasible Solution

- One of the tricky bits of tackling a linear program is to find an initial feasible solution
- We do this in **phase one** of the simplex program
- To do this for each additional constraint we add a new **auxiliary variable** ξ_k , e.g.

$$\forall k \in \{1, 2, \dots, m\} \quad \xi_k + \sum_i A_{ki}x_i = b_k \geq 0$$

- We then can find a basic feasible solution by setting $x_i = 0$ so

$$\xi_k = b_k \quad \forall k \in \{1, 2, \dots, m\}$$

Eliminating Auxiliary Variables

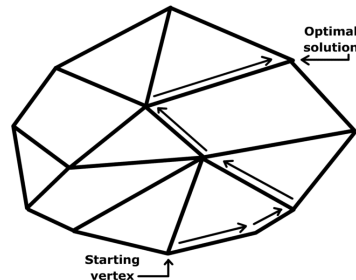
- In phase one we run a simplex algorithm with an auxiliary cost function

$$\min f_{\text{aux}}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\xi}) = \sum_{k=1}^m \xi_k$$

- This should find a solution where all the $\xi_k = 0$
- If no solution exists it means there is no feasible solution and we're finished
- If there is a solution then we can eliminate the auxiliary variables and we have a feasible solution

Outline

1. Recap
2. Basic Feasible Solutions
3. **Simplex Method**
4. Classic LP Problems



Phase Two

- In phase two we now have an initial basic feasible solution (with $n - m$ zero variables)
- We then run the simplex algorithm on the original objective function $f(x) = c \cdot x$
- That is we move to a neighbouring vertex which gives the best increase in the objective function
- To help organise this search we write the objective function and constraints in a **restricted normal form** and then build a **tableau** showing the *basic variables* and the *non-basic variables*

Restricted Normal Form

- To perform the moves between vertices it helps to represent the problem in a **restricted normal form**
- Starting from a basic feasible point we have a constraint for each basic (non-zero) variable
- We write the constraints as an equality between basic and non-basic (zero valued) variables
- Similarly we write the objective function in terms of non-basic variables
- This is always possible as we can use the constraints to eliminate the basic variables

Tableau

$\max_x f(x) = 7.8 - 12.2x_2 - 7.22x_3 - 5.9147x_5 + 28x_6 + 36.7x_6 + 12.16x_9$
 where $x_9 = 1.5 - x_2 - 5.8x_3 - 2.4x_8 + 0.5x_1 + 6x_4 + 0.7x_5 + 10x_6 - 7.5x_7$
 $x_4 = 7.8 - 0.83x_2 + 0.17x_3 + 0.15x_5 + 0.75x_6 + 1.0823x_7 + 0.13x_9$
 $x_8 = 8.6 - 6.25x_2 - 6.25x_3 - 4.52x_5 + 0.7x_6 + 2.19x_7 + 0.10x_9 \geq 0$
 $\max f(x) = 7.8 - 8.23x_2 + 1.9x_3 + 2.9x_5 + 18x_6 + 36x_6 + 12x_7$
 $x_9 = 0.9 - 3.25x_2 - 2.22x_3 + 0.5x_5 + 0.67x_6 + 0.4x_7 + 0.13x_9 \geq 0$
 $\Rightarrow \max f(x) = 7.8 - 8.23x_2 - 7.22x_3 - 0.12x_1 + 24x_6 + 16.16x_6 + 12.16x_9$
 $x_2 = x_3 = x_4 = x_5 = x_6 = x_7 = 0$
 $\Rightarrow x_2 = 0.1, x_3 = 0.83, x_4 = 0.517, x_5 = 0.5, x_6 = 1.08, x_7 = 0.13, x_9 = 0.7$
 $\Rightarrow x_2 = 0.1, x_3 = 0.83, x_4 = 0.517, x_5 = 0.5, x_6 = 1.08, x_7 = 0.13, x_9 = 0.7$

	x_2	x_3	x_4	x_5	x_6	x_7	x_9
$f(x)$	7.8	-8.23	-7.22	-5.91	28	36.7	12.16
x_4	7.8	-0.83	0.17	-0.23	-0.75	-0.83	-0.23
x_8	8.6	-6.25	-6.25	-4.52	0.7	2.19	0.10
x_9	0.9	-3.25	-2.22	0.5	0.67	0.4	0.13

Awkward Problems

- If there are any column with all entries positive then this variable can be increase forever—this is a signal that the linear programming problem is unbounded■
- You can also find that a basic variable becomes zero—this is known as a degenerate feasible vector■
- It can be removed by exchanging variables on the left of the inequality with variables on the right■
- This makes the algorithm a bit more complex to implement■

Time Complexity of Simplex

- The time complexity of the updates is $O(n^2)$ ■
- The critical question is how many updates are necessary■
- It turns out that typically this is $O(n)$ making the simplex algorithm $O(n^3)$ ■
- However, it is possible to cook up problems where there is a “long path” from the initial solution to the optimum which is exponentially big■
- Thus the worst case time is exponential, although this almost never happens in practice■

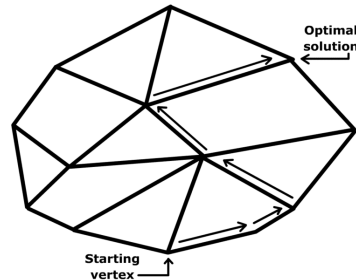
High Performance Solvers

- Although the tableau method is the “classic solver” it doesn’t cut the mustard for large scale problems■
- The simplex update can also be viewed as solving a linear set of equations which is facilitated by performing an LU-decomposition■
- However, the constraints are often very sparse so good solvers try to take advantage of the sparsity■
- Top end simplex algorithms are rather complex■
- There is a second approach known as the interior point method which is competitive on large problems■

Interior Point Method

- An alternative to the simplex method is the interior point method which always remains in the feasible region, away from the constraints■
- These method iterate towards the constraints and are provably polynomial■
- For small linear programming problems they are out-performed in practice by the simplex method■
- On large and very large problems they seem to perform as well if not better than the simplex method■
- The high-end solvers will have a variety of interior point methods tailored to the particular problem■

1. Recap
2. Basic Feasible Solutions
3. Simplex Method
4. **Classic LP Problems**



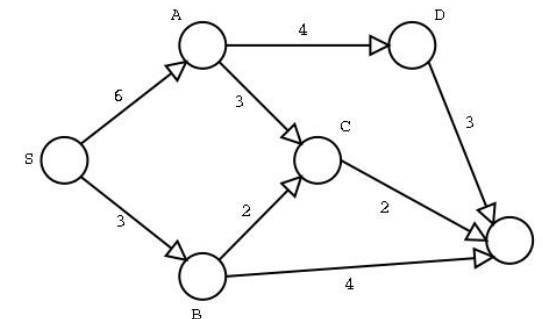
- Any problem that can be set up as a linear program can be solved in polynomial time
- One way is just to feed it to a LP-solver
- Sometimes the problems are important enough and have such a distinctive formulation that faster specialised algorithms have been developed
- We consider a couple of classic problems: *maximum flow* and *linear assignment*

Maximum Flow

- In maximum flow we consider a directed graph representing a network of pipes
- We choose one vertex as the source and a second vertex as a sink
- Each edge has a flow capacity that cannot be exceeded
- The problem is to maximise the flow between source of sink
- This can be used to model the flow of a fluid, parts in an assembly line, current in an electrical circuit or packets through a communication network

Example

- Consider a firm that has to ship haggis from Edinburgh to Southampton
- The shipping firm transports this in crates which it sends through intermediate cities
- The number of crates is limited by the size of the lorries it uses



Flow

- We are given a directed graph $\mathcal{G} = (\mathcal{V}, \mathcal{E})$ where each edge has a capacity $c(i, j)$
- We define the flow from i to j as $f(i, j)$ with $0 \leq f(i, j) \leq c(i, j)$
- For all vertices except the source (s) and sink (t) we assume

$$\forall i \in \mathcal{V} / \{s, t\} \quad \sum_{j \in \mathcal{V} | (i, j) \in \mathcal{E}} f(i, j) = \sum_{j \in \mathcal{V} | (j, i) \in \mathcal{E}} f(j, i)$$

(i.e. no flow is lost from source to sink)

- We want to maximise the flow from the source

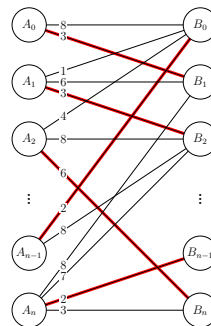
$$\sum_{i \in \mathcal{V} | (s, i) \in \mathcal{E}} f(s, i)$$

Solving Maximum Flow

- As set up we have a linear objective function with linear constraints
- We can therefore solve this problem with a LP-solver
- (Note the solution will typically involve a fraction flow)
- However, this is such a classic problem with a distinctive structure that we can solve it more quickly with other algorithms
- The classic algorithm is the Ford-Fulkerson method with run time $O(|\mathcal{E}| \times f_{\max})$ where $f_{\max}$ is the maximum flow, although we won't cover this in the course

Linear Assignment

- We are given a set of n agents, $\mathcal{A}$, and n tasks, $\mathcal{T}$
- Each agent has a cost associated with performing a task $c(a, t)$
- We want to assign an agent to one task so as to minimise the total cost
- Consider a taxi firm with taxi's at 5 different locations and 5 requests to fulfil. The cost is the distance to the clients. Which taxi should go to which client?



LA as LP

- The linear assignment problem can be set as a linear programming problem

$$\min_{\mathbf{x}} \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}, t \in \mathcal{T}} c(a, t) x_{a, t}$$

subject to

$$\forall a \in \mathcal{A} \quad \sum_{t \in \mathcal{T}} x_{a, t} = 1$$

$$\forall t \in \mathcal{T} \quad \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} x_{a, t} = 1$$

$$\forall (a, t) \in (\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{T}) \quad x_{a, t} \geq 0$$

Hungarian Algorithm

- Linear assignment is another classic problem that is commonly encountered■
- Although it can be solved using a generic LP-solver this is not the most efficient algorithm■
- The most efficient algorithm is the Hungarian algorithms■
- This is rather complex (having once implemented it I can tell you from bitter experience it ain't easy)■
- Its worst case time is $O(n^3)$ although it frequently takes $\Theta(n^2)$ ■

Quadratic Programming

- If we have linear constraints and a quadratic objective function then we have a quadratic programming problem■
- Again this can be solved in polynomial time■
- Many of the ideas used are the same as for linear programming■
- This also has important applications in science and engineering■

Lessons

- Linear programming is a classic problem■
- We know a huge number of problems are solvable in polynomial time because they can be formulated as linear programs■
- Linear programs occur sufficiently often that they are hugely important■
- They aren't easy to solve, although standard simplex is not massively complex■
- For particular LP problems with distinctive structure there are sometimes better algorithms than generic LP-solvers■